

Recommendation Rabbit Hole Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Technology • 30-40 min

Category	Knowledge and Technology	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	recommendation-rabbit-hole

Big idea: A feed can become a path dependency: early clicks shape later knowledge possibilities.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students simulate repeated recommendations and observe how small choices can narrow a user's knowledge environment.

Student Prompt

Inspect Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Starting interest: exam stress; feed branches into study tips, productivity hacks, anxiety posts, tutoring adverts, and sleep science. Rank, sort, or audit this output. Identify which rule, ranking signal, or interface choice shaped your judgement.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Starting interest: climate action; feed branches into science explainers, activism, conspiracy claims, policy debate, and lifestyle content. Rank, sort, or audit this output. Identify which rule, ranking signal, or interface choice shaped your judgement.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Recommendation Rabbit Hole Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Starting interest: climate action; feed branches into science explainers, activism, conspiracy claims, policy debate, and lifestyle content. Rank, sort, or audit this output. Identify which rule, ranking signal, or interface choice shaped your judgement.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — A feed can become a path dependency: early clicks shape later knowledge possibilities.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	When does personalization become distortion?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Technology.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how a feed can become a path dependency: early clicks shape later knowledge possibilities.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: When does personalization become distortion?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare enough cards that each round can narrow without becoming repetitive.
- Keep content fictional and school-safe while preserving emotional and credibility differences.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Starting interest: exam stress; feed branches into study tips, productivity hacks, anxiety posts, tutoring adverts, and sleep science.
- Starting interest: climate action; feed branches into science explainers, activism, conspiracy claims, policy debate, and lifestyle content.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/recommendation-rabbit-hole/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/recommendation-rabbit-hole/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/recommendation-rabbit-hole/visual-prompt.svg>
- Feed path tracker with rounds, clicked item, new recommendations, and perceived worldview.
- Recommendation rule cards: similar topic, stronger emotion, most engaged, highest reliability.

Run Sequence

1. Give each student or group a starting interest card.
2. Students choose one item from a small feed of mixed content.

3. The algorithm adds more cards similar to the chosen card in the next round.
4. Repeat for three or four rounds and map how feeds diverge.
5. Debrief what users might come to believe is normal, popular, or true.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: When does personalization become distortion?
- Is a recommendation a neutral convenience or an argument about relevance?
- Who is responsible for the knowledge environment created by a feed?

Teacher Quick Script

- The user keeps choosing, but the menu of choices keeps changing.
- At what point does personalization become a knowledge environment?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...